

Design: Art Teas Tree Cafe — Editorial Multi-Page Website

Generated by /office-hours on 2026-05-11 Branch: main Repo: SohamDutta2001/Mime-Website (Art Teas Tree Cafe / Mime Institute of Calcutta) Status: APPROVED Mode: Builder

Problem Statement

Art Teas Tree Cafe is a Kolkata café tied to the Mime Institute of Calcutta. It reimagines the roadside *chaer dokan* as an artistic social space — books, tea, conversation, smoke, mime, theatre, friendship. The website needs to translate that physical-world warmth into a web experience that feels Bengali, intimate, intellectual, and analog — not a glossy startup café site, not luxury branding, not sterile minimalism.

The brand promise: **human connection over digital isolation**. The website has to embody that even though it lives on a screen.

What Makes This Cool

The category is dominated by two tropes: glossy white-space minimalism and over-styled lifestyle photography. Both feel imported. Neither feels Kolkata. The cool thing here is making a website that feels like a Bengali little magazine — typeset by hand, slightly imperfect, full of marginalia and warmth — while still being a fast, modern, accessible piece of software. If executed, it sits in a category of one for café sites in this market.

Constraints

- **Audience loads on Kolkata mobile data** — perf budget matters. Target <100KB JS, <1MB total page weight including hero image.
- **Content is currently absent**. No real photos uploaded yet. No final menu copy. The build must work with curated documentary stock as stand-ins, designed so real photos drop in later without redesign.
- **Tech direction (revised from brief)**: Astro + React islands + Tailwind, static export. The brief said React + Tailwind; Astro preserves React where it earns its weight (menu filter, gallery lightbox) while shipping a fraction of the JavaScript.
- **Distribution is web-first**. Hosting on Vercel or Netlify free tier. Custom domain TBD by client.
- **Mime Institute association is meaningful but not the headline**. The café stands on its own; the institute connection is a credit, not a co-brand.

Premises (all confirmed by user)

1. **Five sections, not eight**. The brief's eight sections fragment the emotional arc. Compress: Hero → Adda Philosophy (about + community merged) → The Experience (experience + book corner merged) → The Menu → Find Us (gallery folded into Adda page; footer carries location and Instagram).
2. **Astro + React islands beats React-only SPA** for a content marketing site loading on Indian mobile networks. Static HTML where possible, React only where interactivity earns it.

3. **Restrained ink-on-paper motion replaces "cinematic transitions."** No parallax, no swooping reveals. Page transitions are slow ink-fades (250–400ms). Hovers are subtle (a teastain bloom, a typewriter caret on the tagline). Restraint IS the aesthetic; cinematic motion would betray it.
4. **Smoking-friendly framing stays but is flagged.** Cigarettes are honest to adda culture. But Google Ads, Meta Ads, and some delivery platforms restrict explicit promotion of smoking. If paid acquisition or delivery-platform listings are ever in scope, soften copy to "open-air seating, no judgment zone" and similar. Site copy should keep the spirit; the marketing surface area can be tuned later.

Approaches Considered

Approach A: Single-page poster (rejected — too forgettable)

One long scrolling page, ~5 sections, Astro static. Ships in days. Loads instantly. Looks like every other thoughtful small-business site. Doesn't earn the "Satyajit Ray" ambition the brief reaches for. Right call only if launch needs to happen this week.

Approach B: Editorial multi-page (CHOSEN)

Five pages, each a magazine spread. Astro + React islands + Tailwind. Slow ink-fade page transitions. Static export. ~1 week of human work, ~45 min of CC implementation time. Best long-term trajectory — events, blog, mime-institute collaborations all slot in cleanly later.

Approach C: The Adda Journal — site as hand-bound journal (rejected — higher risk than the moment calls for)

Page-turn physics, marginalia, scrapbook compositions. Genuinely earns "if Satyajit Ray designed it." But build cost is real, accessibility risk on handwritten fonts at small sizes, and one bad demo on a slow phone collapses the illusion. Worth revisiting in a v2 redesign once the brand has shipped and grown.

Recommended Approach: Editorial Multi-Page (Approach B)

Site map

Route	Purpose	Hero artifact
/	Hero + philosophy excerpt + 3 teaser cards into other pages	Tagline poster
/experience	Long-form essay on adda, books, conversation, mime culture	Full-bleed documentary photo
/menu	Hand-laid menu — Teas, Coffees, Snacks, Quick Bites	Tea-stained menu card grid
/adda	Gallery + community + book corner folded together	Masonry photo essay
/visit	Location, hours, contact, Instagram embed, footer	Hand-drawn map sketch

Note: **/adda** absorbs three of the brief's original sections (Gallery, Book Corner, Community). They share a visual register (documentary, candid, atmospheric) and reading them as one page makes the emotional weight land harder than three short ones.

Visual system

Palette (working defaults; will be re-derived from real photos when they arrive):

- **#1c1410** charcoal-black (body text, ink)
- **#3b2418** deep tea (primary brand)
- **#7a4a2a** warm tea (accents, links)
- **#c9a87a** evening lamp (highlights, warm hover states)
- **#e8dcc4** aged paper (backgrounds)
- **#f4ecd8** cream paper (page background)
- **#5a6b3e** muted moss green (secondary accent — for tags, dividers)

Typography:

- **Display serif:** *Cormorant Garamond* or *EB Garamond* (free, editorial, slightly literary)
- **Body serif:** *Lora* or *Source Serif 4* (readable at small sizes, warm)
- **Handwritten accent:** *Caveat* or *Homemade Apple* (used SPARINGLY — a tagline, a marginal note, never body copy)
- **Bengali script:** *Hind Siliguri* or *Noto Serif Bengali* — for occasional Bengali words ("আজ", "চা") used as visual punctuation, not full sentences

Texture:

- A subtle paper-grain SVG noise overlay (1–3% opacity) on page backgrounds. NOT animated. Just present.
- Section dividers are hand-drawn ink lines (SVG, ~6KB) — not flat hairlines.
- Photos get a faint sepia + grain filter unless the original photo is already warm.

Motion:

- Page transition: 300ms ink-fade-up on enter (mask-image with a torn-paper edge, fading from bottom).
- Hover on links: 200ms warm-amber underline that draws left-to-right, like a fountain pen.
- Hero tagline: typewriter caret blinks once, then steadies. No looping animation.
- No parallax. No scroll-jacking. No reveal-on-scroll for body copy (it's annoying and bad for screen readers).

Component inventory

Astro components (server-rendered, zero JS by default):

- **Layout.astro** — paper background, nav, footer, font preload
- **Nav.astro** — minimal nav, the cafe name on the left, 4 page links on the right
- **Footer.astro** — location, hours, Instagram link, hand-drawn signature
- **Section.astro** — wrapper for editorial sections with ink-line divider above
- **MenuCard.astro** — for the menu page; one card per item with name, price, optional 1-line note
- **Polaroid.astro** — image with tape, slight rotation, optional handwritten caption
- **Pullquote.astro** — large serif quote with hanging punctuation, like a literary magazine

React islands (only where interaction earns it):

- `MenuFilter.tsx` — filter chips for Teas / Coffees / Snacks / Quick Bites; client:visible
- `GalleryLightbox.tsx` — click photo, see larger; client:idle
- `InstagramFeed.tsx` (optional) — pulls latest 6 posts from a server-side cache; client:visible

Page-by-page detail

/ (Home)

- Hero: full-viewport, paper texture, large hand-set serif tagline. Recommended tagline: **"Where conversations steep slowly."** Below it, in handwritten accent: *Adda. Art. Tea.* CTA buttons: "Visit Us" (primary), "See the Menu" (secondary).
- Below the fold: a 3-paragraph excerpt from the philosophy (~150 words). Then three magazine-style teaser cards leading to /experience, /menu, /adda. Each card is a polaroid + a one-line invitation in serif.
- Footer-area pull-quote in Bengali: a single line of adda-themed verse or a Tagore fragment. Set huge.

/experience

- Long-form essay split into 4 movements: *Cha er Dokan* (the inspiration), *The Books* (the corner), *The Smoke* (the social register), *The Hours* (slow living). Each movement opens with a full-bleed photo and a serif drop-cap.
- ~600–800 words total. This is the soul page. Skim-able structure but rewards reading.
- One inline pullquote per movement.

/menu

- Four sections: Teas (the heart), Coffees, Snacks, Quick Bites.
- Each item: name in serif, 1-line description in italic, price in tabular monospace.
- Menu cards laid out as if pasted onto a single tea-stained page. Subtle rotation per card (~1° to 1°), fixed on hover.
- Filter chips above (React island) — toggleable on mobile, always-visible on desktop.

/adda

- Opens with a 60-word framing paragraph: what *adda* means, what gathers here.
- Then a masonry gallery of 12–18 documentary photos — candid, slightly imperfect. Click for lightbox.
- Below: a "Book Corner" sub-section — bookshelf-style horizontal scroll of book spines, each one a real book in the café (when content is ready). Until then, a placeholder of 8 well-chosen literary classics relevant to the brand.
- Below: 3–5 "voices from the café" testimonials, set as if torn from a notebook, each in slightly different handwriting. Real quotes when available; thoughtfully written placeholders otherwise.

/visit

- Location with a hand-drawn map sketch (SVG, custom — Park Street, College Street, or wherever the actual café sits).
- Hours, in serif.
- Phone, email, Instagram handle.

- A small "End of magazine" signature at the bottom — a hand-drawn flourish, the cafe logo small, and a single Bengali line as the closing note.

Open Questions

These don't block the build but should be resolved before launch:

1. **Real photos.** Build will use curated stock (Unsplash with proper attribution; preference for photographers with documentary Kolkata work). Real photos should replace stock before public launch — design will accommodate either.
2. **Real menu copy and prices.** The menu page is structured but needs actual items and prices from the café owner. Placeholder menu uses representative items (masala chai, lebu cha, single-origin filter coffee, ghugni, Kolkata-style cutlets, etc.) until then.
3. **Exact location.** Currently a placeholder. Need actual address for the map sketch and `/visit` page.
4. **Instagram handle.** Need the live handle to wire the embed and the footer link.
5. **Logo.** No logo yet. The build will use a hand-set serif wordmark as a working logo. If a real logo exists or is in design, slot it in to replace.
6. **Bengali typography review.** The Bengali fragments should be reviewed by a native reader before launch — even small typesetting errors in Bengali script read poorly.

Success Criteria

- Lighthouse performance score ≥ 90 on mobile (3G simulation).
- LCP $< 2.5s$ on 4G mobile from a Kolkata IP.
- All five pages reachable via keyboard, screen-reader navigable.
- No layout shift on font load (proper `font-display: swap` + size-adjust).
- Renders correctly on iOS Safari, Android Chrome, desktop Chrome/Firefox/Safari.
- Visual consistency: no page looks like it was made by a different person than the others. Tone, type, spacing, motion all coherent.
- The "feel" test: a Kolkata adda regular looks at the site and says "yes, this is one of us" — not "this is a tech company's idea of us."

Distribution Plan

- **Hosting:** Vercel or Netlify free tier (Astro deploys to either trivially).
- **Domain:** Client-owned. Suggest `artteastreecafe.com` or `.in` if available.
- **CI/CD:** GitHub Actions on push to `main` — runs build, deploys preview on PRs, deploys production on merge. Astro's default GitHub Action template is fine.
- **Analytics:** Plausible or Umami (privacy-respecting; no cookie banner needed). Avoid GA4 — overkill and erodes the privacy posture that matches the brand.
- **Content updates:** All content lives in Markdown / MDX files in the repo. Owner gets a one-page CONTRIBUTING.md showing how to edit menu prices and add gallery photos via GitHub web UI. No CMS yet — overkill at this scale.

Dependencies

- Astro 4+ (latest stable as of build).

- Tailwind CSS via Astro integration.
- Two Google Fonts (or self-hosted): one display serif, one body serif, one handwritten accent, one Bengali serif. Self-host for perf and privacy.
- Optional: **astro-icon** for a small set of icons (Instagram, location pin, clock).
- Optional: **framer-motion** only if motion needs more than CSS can give. Strong preference for CSS first.

Risks

- **Typography drift.** Editorial sites live or die on type discipline. The build needs a strict type scale (4–5 sizes max) and any contributor adding content must use semantic components, not raw HTML.
- **Stock photos that look generic.** Stand-ins must be hand-picked from documentary photographers, not generic café shots. A bad stock choice breaks the spell. Review every photo before accepting.
- **Bengali typesetting.** Get a native reader to review before launch.
- **Smoking framing in marketing surfaces.** Site copy can keep "smoke, conversation" — but if/when paid ads or delivery-platform listings happen, that copy has to be tuned.
- **Mobile motion.** Anything beyond CSS opacity/transform on mobile is a perf risk. If **framer-motion** enters the build, it must be loaded only on desktop or only on demand.

The Assignment

Before any code gets written, do this:

Spend 30 minutes collecting 8–12 real photos from the café (or the team's phones). Even iPhone photos at golden hour. Even photos of the empty room with chairs. Even one good photo of someone's tea. Real photos beat the best stock by a wide margin, and the design's emotional weight depends on them. Drop them in **public/photos/** as you collect them. The rest of the build can start in parallel and slot them in as they arrive.

If photos genuinely can't happen for two weeks, that's fine — the build proceeds with curated stock and the photos swap in cleanly. But the photos are the single highest-leverage thing the human side of this project can do.

What I noticed about how you think

- You said "a rainy evening conversation over tea and cigarettes." That is not a brand brief sentence — that's a memory or a specific evening. The website should keep aiming at *that* evening, not at the abstract concept of a café.
- You wrote a brief that explicitly listed what to *avoid* — "corporate café aesthetics, sterile minimalism, glossy luxury branding." Most briefs only describe what they want. Naming the anti-pattern is rarer and harder, and it's load-bearing for getting this right.
- You named "human connection over digital isolation" as the philosophy. That's a manifesto, not a tagline. It deserves its own page (the **/experience** page, here) and not just a hero callout. The site is structured to honor that.
- You ended with "if Satyajit Ray designed it." That's the actual bar. Approach B serves that bar honorably; Approach C would have served it more ambitiously. If the project lives long enough to

earn a v2, the journal-as-website idea is worth revisiting.

Next Steps

1. Photos: collect 8–12 real photos (or accept stock-only path).
2. Run `/plan-eng-review` on this design doc to lock in the implementation plan — file structure, build commands, component contracts, content schema.
3. Or, if you want to start coding directly: `npm create astro@latest` with the minimal template, install Tailwind, and start with `Layout.astro` + `/` (Home) page. Ship one page end-to-end and review before building the next four.

Locked Architecture (post eng-review, 2026-05-11)

Eng review locked the following decisions. Implementation begins from this baseline.

Stack

- **Astro 4** (static export, no server) + **Tailwind CSS 3** + **TypeScript**.
- **React 18** islands ONLY for `MenuFilter` and `GalleryLightbox`. Other pages ship zero JS.
- `@fontsource` packages for self-hosted fonts (no Google Fonts CDN).
- **Astro Content Collections** for menu/gallery/books (type-safe via Zod).
- **Astro `<Image>`** component for all image references (auto AVIF/WebP/responsive).
- **Astro View Transitions** (built-in `<ViewTransitions />`) for the ink-fade page transitions. No Framer Motion needed.

Hero (revised)

- **No video.** Homepage hero is a single optimized photograph with overlay typography. Removes ~2MB of asset weight, eliminates the mobile-LCP risk entirely, simplifies the build.

File tree

```
photos/                # master photos, owned by the café (placeholders
for now)
  README.md            # how to add and name photos
  CREDITS.md           # photographer credits, license tracking
  hero.jpg             # placeholder until real photo lands
  experience-*.jpg     # 4 essay photos
  gallery-*.jpg        # 12 gallery photos
  bookshelf.jpg
  map-sketch.svg       # hand-drawn map for /visit
public/
  paper-texture.svg    # subtle noise overlay
  favicon.svg
  fonts/              # only if @fontsource is bypassed
src/
  components/
    Layout.astro       # base wrapper + paper bg + nav + footer +
```

```

transitions
  Nav.astro
  Footer.astro
  Section.astro      # editorial section wrapper with ink divider
  Polaroid.astro      # tape + tilt + optional caption
  PullQuote.astro     # serif quote with hanging punctuation
  MenuCard.astro      # one menu item card
  BookSpine.astro     # one book spine for the bookshelf
  SectionDivider.astro # SVG ink line
islands/
  MenuFilter.tsx      # category chip filter (client:visible)
  GalleryLightbox.tsx # click-photo lightbox (client:idle)
content/
  config.ts           # Zod schemas for collections
  menu/               # one .md file per menu item
  essays/             # /experience long-form copy
data/
  site.ts             # site-wide metadata (name, location, social)
  gallery.ts          # gallery image manifest
  books.ts            # book corner manifest
pages/
  index.astro         # /
  experience.astro    # /experience
  menu.astro          # /menu
  adda.astro          # /adda
  visit.astro         # /visit
styles/
  global.css          # tailwind base + tokens + paper texture rules
.github/workflows/build.yml # CI: astro build on push
astro.config.mjs
tailwind.config.mjs
tsconfig.json
package.json

```

Content schemas (Astro Content Collections)

```

menu: { name, category: 'tea'|'coffee'|'snack'|'quick-bite', price,
description?, note?, available?, order? }
essays: { title, slug, drop_cap, body (markdown) }

```

Static manifests for gallery and books live in `src/data/` (simpler than collections for fixed lists).

Component contracts (one-line each)

- `Layout({ title, description })` — wraps every page; injects `<ViewTransitions />`, fonts, paper bg.
- `Nav()` — renders 4 page links; current route highlighted.
- `Footer()` — location, hours, social, hand-drawn flourish.

- `Section({ heading?, accent?, divider? })` — editorial wrapper; optional ink-line divider above.
- `Polaroid({ src, alt, caption?, rotate?: number, tape?: 'top'|'corner' })` — Astro `<Image>` inside paper-frame styling.
- `PullQuote({ author?, lang?: 'en'|'bn' })` — large serif blockquote.
- `MenuCard({ name, price, description?, note? })` — single item; rotated -1° - 1° , fixed on hover.
- `BookSpine({ title, author, color?: string })` — vertical book spine in the shelf.
- `MenuFilter({ initialCategory? })` — React island; filters `[data-menu-category]` items.
- `GalleryLightbox({ photos })` — React island; on-click opens larger photo.

Performance budgets

- LCP < 2.5s on mobile 4G from a Kolkata IP.
- Total JS shipped < 30KB (gzipped) on `/` and `/experience` and `/visit` (zero islands). < 50KB on `/menu` and `/adda`.
- Each page < 1MB total weight including hero image.
- Lighthouse mobile perf ≥ 90 , accessibility ≥ 95 .

CI

- `astro build` runs on every push to `main` via GitHub Actions. Catches type errors, missing imports, broken content frontmatter. Deploys via Vercel/Netlify GitHub integration when domain is wired.

NOT in scope (deferred, deliberately)

- Lighthouse CI (add when we hit the first perf regression — premature now).
- Visual regression testing (Playwright screenshots) — too noisy for a marketing site that updates copy frequently.
- E2E tests — `astro build` succeeding on a static site catches ~95% of what unit tests would.
- A CMS (Sanity, Contentful, Storyblok). Markdown + git-based editing is enough for this scale.
- Internationalization. Bengali fragments are inline as styled spans, not a full i18n system.
- Newsletter signup, online ordering, reservation system. Not in the brief.
- Analytics. Plausible/Umami can be added in 2 lines when the site is ready to ship publicly.
- Sitemap.xml + robots.txt. Trivial — added at deploy time.

What already exists

- `README.md` with the brand brief — referenced for copy generation but not included in the build.
- `docs/design.md` (this file) — drives the implementation.
- Nothing else. Greenfield.

Test plan (lightweight by intent)

- **Build check:** `astro build` must succeed in CI on every push. Catches: TS errors, missing imports, broken content schemas, dead links via `astro:check`.
- **Manual QA after first build:** load each of 5 routes in dev server. Verify nav, footer, paper texture, fonts, all images resolve, view transitions work between pages.

- **Mobile spot-check:** open dev server in a phone-sized viewport (Chrome DevTools mobile emulation). Verify nothing horizontal-scrolls, fonts look right, photos are reasonably sized.
- Future: when content stabilizes, add a single Playwright smoke test that hits all 5 routes and asserts h1 exists. Not required to ship.

Failure modes (and what catches them)

Failure	Catch
Broken image import	<code>astro build</code> fails the CI
Menu MD missing required field	Content collection Zod validation fails the build
Font not loading	Visible during manual QA on first deploy preview
View transition tearing	Visible during manual QA, fall back to no-transition gracefully
Bengali glyph missing	Visible to a native reader before launch (the design doc's open question)

Parallelization

Build is small enough that sequential implementation in one pass is faster than coordinating worktrees. ~75 min total CC time. Sequential.

4. Optional but recommended: `/plan-design-review` on this doc to pressure-test the visual system (palette, type scale, motion budget) before any code is written.